

QA LEADERSHIP ACADEMY

QA Interview Question Bank

Questions grouped by what they reveal — with what a strong versus weak answer sounds like — not trivia to be memorised.

Purpose

This bank gives you interview questions organised by the quality they assess — critical thinking, communication, technical depth and learning potential — each paired with what a strong and a weak answer actually sound like. The aim is to probe how someone thinks, not whether they have memorised definitions. Anyone can recite "severity is technical impact, priority is business urgency"; far fewer can reason well about a messy, ambiguous situation.

When to use it

- To build a structured interview where every candidate is asked the same core questions.
- To prepare a panel so interviewers know what a good answer looks like before they hear one.
- To replace trivia rounds ("name the phases of the STLC") with questions that discriminate between capable and less-capable testers.

Instructions

1. Choose two to three questions per area based on what your role most needs.
2. Ask the same core set of every candidate for the role — that is what makes the comparison fair.
3. Listen for the reasoning behind the answer and follow up with "why?" and "what would change your mind?".
4. Score against the strong/weak indicators, not against how confidently the person spoke.
5. Leave room for the candidate to ask questions — the questions a good tester asks are themselves a signal.

Worked example

A selection from the bank, with indicators, as used for Northstar's automation-focused senior role.

Critical thinking

Question	Strong answer	Weak answer
We have 1,800 UI automated tests, they take six hours and a quarter of them are flaky. Where do you start?	Diagnoses before acting: asks what the flakiness costs, categorises failures by cause, questions whether all 1,800 are worth keeping, and proposes stabilising the highest-value tests first rather than "rewrite it all".	Jumps straight to a tool or a rewrite; assumes more tests are always better; no sense of prioritising by value or root cause.
A developer says "good developers don't need a QA team." How do you respond?	Engages with the point rather than defending territory; distinguishes testing (an activity everyone shares) from a QA function; argues in terms of risk and outcomes; open to a model where quality is shared.	Defensive or dismissive; asserts QA is essential without evidence; treats it as a personal attack.

Communication

Question	Strong answer	Weak answer
A release is at risk on quality but Product wants to ship on the date. How do you have that conversation?	Frames residual risk clearly and in business terms; offers options and their trade-offs rather than a flat "no"; makes the risk owner's decision explicit; stays collaborative.	Either caves immediately or blocks flatly; talks in test-case counts rather than risk; makes it a standoff.
Explain a flaky test to a non-technical stakeholder.	Uses a plain analogy, avoids jargon, focuses on the consequence (wasted time, lost trust) rather than the mechanism.	Drowns the listener in technical detail; cannot translate out of engineer-speak.

Technical depth

Question	Strong answer	Weak answer
How do you decide what to automate and what to keep as manual/exploratory?	Reasons about value, stability, frequency and cost of the check; knows automation is not free and has a maintenance cost; keeps exploratory testing for the things automation cannot judge.	"Automate everything" or "automate the regression pack" with no reasoning about cost or value.
What makes an automated test suite trustworthy?	Talks about reliability (low flakiness), speed, clear failures, shared ownership and being run on every change — not just coverage numbers.	Equates trust with a high coverage percentage; no mention of flakiness or ownership.

Learning potential

Question	Strong answer	Weak answer
Tell me about a time you were wrong about a technical decision.	Gives a specific example, owns it without defensiveness, and describes what they changed as a result.	Cannot think of one, or reframes a strength as a weakness ("I care too much").
How did you learn the most recent new tool or technique you picked up?	Concrete, recent, self-directed; shows genuine curiosity and a method for learning.	Vague, out of date, or entirely dependent on being sent on a course.

HR AND LEGAL NOTE

This is a decision-support tool, not legal advice. Always run your process through your own HR/People team and follow local employment law on data handling, right-to-work, records retention, reasonable adjustments and non-discrimination. Ask every candidate for a role the same questions against the same criteria, record the evidence rather than the impression, and keep your notes factual — they may be disclosable.

How to interpret the results

- Reward the quality of reasoning over the neatness of the conclusion. A candidate who reasons well from wrong assumptions is more coachable than one who recites a right answer with no understanding.
- A strong answer to the "developer doesn't need QA" question matters especially at Northstar, where a real squad lead holds exactly that view — map answers back to the actual environment.
- Consistent weak answers on learning potential outweigh a strong technical score for a fast-changing role — skills date, the ability to learn does not.
- Judge answers against the indicators, not against the most articulate candidate. Fluency is not the same as insight.

Blank reusable version

Area	Question	Strong answer	Weak answer
Critical thinking			
Communication			
Technical depth			
Learning potential			

Common mistakes

COMMON MISTAKES

Trivia questions that reward memorisation over thinking. Asking each candidate a different set, so no fair comparison is possible. Leading the witness ("so you'd automate that, right?"). Scoring confidence and fluency instead of reasoning, which favours the well-rehearsed over the genuinely capable. Gotcha puzzles that test nothing relevant to the job. Never leaving time for the candidate's own questions.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

The best follow-up in any QA interview is "what would make you change your mind?" Testers earn their keep by seeking disconfirming evidence — a candidate who can name what would falsify their own answer is showing you exactly the instinct the job needs.